

Practice Paper 10 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — Difficulty opening the wardrobe

1 mark each for any two of:

- She had “walked past it every morning, every evening” without opening it.
- On nights when she could not sleep she had “stood before it” with her hand on the brass knob.
- She had then “taken [her] hand away again” — i.e. she could not bring herself to open it.
- She had been “certain” the hinges “would protest” — suggesting she expected resistance because it had not been opened for so long.

Q2. [2] — Reaction to the order of the shirts (own words)

1 mark — She is **taken by surprise** / had not anticipated such a strong emotional response.

1 mark — The mere **tidiness** of his shirts **overwhelms her** / breaks her composure, because it recalls his careful, methodical way of doing everything.

Reject lifts of “undo me” without rewording.

Q3. [2] — Comparison to a child’s coat

1 mark — The comparison suggests **tenderness** and a sense of holding something **precious that no longer has its owner**.

1 mark — It captures the **aching absence** of her husband — like a parent confronted with how much a lost or grown child has changed; the shirt is a body-shaped reminder of someone who is no longer there to fill it.

Q4. [2] — Why the radio was left on (own words)

1 mark — Partly out of **habit** — she had grown used to its presence over many years.

1 mark — Partly because the **low sound resembled his breathing** / it gave her the comforting illusion that he was still in the next room.

Q5. [1] — Effect of the word “intolerable”

1 mark — It suggests her grief was **still raw** / she found the **complete silence unbearable**, because it confirmed his absence in a way the radio had previously hidden. (Also accept: **deeply painful, overwhelming**.)

Q6. [2] — “Later... a useful country”

1 mark — The image presents “later” as a **place one travels to occasionally** — i.e. she allows herself to **defer difficult decisions** about his belongings.

1 mark — It suggests she is **managing** her grief by **postponing** the most painful choices to a future visit, rather than facing them all at once.

Q7. [1] — Emotional shock on finding the letter

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- “I sat down on the edge of the bed because my legs would not, just then, hold me.”
- “I did not open it at once.”
- She “held it for a long time, between two fingers”.
- The simile that it could “yet turn out to be a dream” — she is afraid it is not real.

Q8. [2] — Two things about the husband’s character (own words)

1 mark each for any two of:

- He was **practical** / **methodical** — the letter is a list of useful instructions (keys, plumber, password).
- He was **thoughtful** / **caring** — he anticipated what she would need to know after he was gone.
- He had a **gentle sense of humour** — the postscript teasingly tells her to “stop being sensible” and meet a friend.
- He was **concerned for her welfare beyond practical matters** — he urged her to keep up her friendships / not isolate herself.

Reject simple lifts (“characteristic”, “sensible”) without explanation.

Q9. [2] — Laughing and crying together

1 mark — It suggests her emotions are **mixed** / she is feeling **grief and affection** / **happiness at once**.

1 mark — It suggests she has reached a stage in her grief where **sorrow and tenderness are no longer separable**, and a small moment of love can produce **both** responses simultaneously.

Q10. [2] — Daughter’s short line of speech

1 mark — The brevity conveys that the daughter is **too moved to say more** / words have failed her.

1 mark — The short line is more **powerful and intimate** than a longer speech would be — it suggests the **immediate, instinctive sympathy** of a child for a grieving parent, and the shared understanding that does not need words.

Q11. [2] — The wardrobe left ajar

1 mark — The narrator no longer wishes to **shut the past away completely** — leaving the door open shows she has begun to accept her loss.

1 mark — The “finger’s width of light” symbolises a **small but real opening** / the beginning of **re-entry into life** and a **gentle hope**, contrasting with the firmly closed wardrobe of the past year.

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — Two facts on declining sleep

1 mark each for any two of:

- A hundred and fifty years ago adults slept “between eight and nine hours a night”.
- That figure has fallen today to “a little under seven” hours.
- Among young professionals in busy cities the figure has “slipped lower still”.

Q13. [2] — “A contested resource” (own words)

1 mark — **Contested** suggests sleep is now **fought over** / **disputed** / no longer taken for granted.

1 mark — **Resource** suggests it is treated as something **limited and valuable** that has to be **budgeted or rationed**, like time or money — rather than as a natural, automatic part of life.

Q14. [2] — How the bulb changed night-time (own words)

1 mark — Before electric light, people **stopped activity when the sun set** — candles and oil lamps were too dim to allow any serious work.

1 mark — The bulb allowed people to **carry on working and living far into the night, extending the active day artificially** beyond natural daylight.

Q15. [2] — “A small bright rectangle...”

1 mark — The deliberately **flat, clinical description** makes the phone sound **trivial and harmless**, which sharpens the contrast with its very real biological effect.

1 mark — Reducing the phone to **its physical shape and brightness** makes the absurdity vivid: a **tiny object, held inches from the face**, has been allowed to **override the body’s ancient sleep signals**.

Q16. [1] — Inverted commas around “four-hour nights”

1 mark — The inverted commas show the writer is **quoting** / **reporting** the boasted phrase rather than endorsing it; they signal **scepticism** / a touch of **disapproval** at the way executives wear so little sleep as a badge of honour. (Also accept: distancing himself from the claim.)

Q17. [2] — “Exhaustion... a badge of seriousness” (own words)

1 mark — **Tiredness** is now treated as **evidence of hard work and ambition**.

1 mark — **Perversely** shows the writer thinks this is **deeply wrong-headed** — people **boast** about a state that should worry them, and adequate sleep is wrongly seen as laziness or weakness.

Q18. [2] — Comparison to blood-alcohol level

1 mark — The comparison makes the **cognitive harm of tiredness measurable and shocking** — equating sleep loss with **drunkenness**.

1 mark — It exposes the **hypocrisy** / **inconsistency** in our standards: we forbid a drunk colleague

from working, yet routinely allow ourselves to work in an equivalently impaired state. (Accept: makes danger of tired working concrete and undeniable.)

Q19. [2] — Why “go to bed earlier” misses the problem

1 mark each for any two of:

- Shift workers cannot choose when they are required to be awake.
- Parents (especially mothers) are at the mercy of small children’s needs at night.
- Junior professionals in finance and law are expected to answer emails late at night and very early in the morning.

Each detail must be **clearly stated**; vague gestures at “they are busy” = ½ mark.

Q20. [1] — Attitude towards forward-thinking firms

1 mark — **Approving / commendatory / supportive**. (Also accept: **admiring, positive**. Reject: **neutral, sceptical**.)

Q21. [2] — Sleep as “medicine”

1 mark — Calling sleep **medicine** turns it from a **passive activity** into an **active treatment** that prevents and heals illness.

1 mark — **Cheapest and most effective** underlines that, unlike most medicines, sleep costs **nothing**, has **no side-effects**, and is **available to everyone** — yet most people refuse to “take” it.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.

Reasons people sleep less today (Paragraphs 2–3 and 5):

1. The **electric light bulb** extended the working day far beyond sunset.
2. **Screens** (television, computer, phone) **suppress the brain’s natural sleep signals** with bright light at night.
3. A **cultural shift** has made early rising a virtue and full sleep a sign of weakness / **productivity culture** treats sleep as time wasted.
4. **Structural pressures** such as shift work, parenting, and after-hours work emails make adequate sleep impossible for many.

What employers, schools and individuals can do (Paragraph 6):

5. **Firms** can **ban after-hours emails** and provide **nap rooms** for staff on long shifts.
6. **Workplaces** can treat **sleep deprivation as a safety issue**, like other workplace hazards.
7. **Schools** can **start the secondary day later**, which improves performance and reduces teen road accidents.
8. **Individuals** should keep the **bedroom dark and cool**, leave the **phone in another room**, and **go to bed and wake at consistent times**.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

People today sleep less than their grandparents because electric lighting and bright screens stretch the day past sunset and overrule the body’s natural cues for rest. A culture of productivity has also recast sleep as wasted time, while shift work, childcare and late-night emails leave many

with no choice. To fix this, firms can forbid after-hours emails, offer nap rooms and treat tiredness as a safety hazard; schools can start later; individuals should darken bedrooms, banish phones and keep regular hours.

Length count: 78 words from “People” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —